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Culture (OWC): [Luguru \(FN32\)](#)

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Place Coverage

Uluguru Mountains, Morogoro Region, Tanzania

Section Title(S)

Second Case: Salima • The Pregnancy rite (kupewa nguo) • The Sexual Resumption Rite

The Pregnancy rite (kupewa nguo)

A continuation of the puberty rite was followed when she was seven months pregnant. This was basically a way of counseling the expectant mother on safe motherhood and delivery. During this ceremony, she was covered with a cloth (kupewa nguo) and then presented to the world of women who had already borne children. They taught her about child birth and demonstrated to her the place where the baby would make its exit into the world. They explained to her how she should behave and cooperate with the birth attendants. They told her about the placenta and how to push and when to push. During this rite women talked of their experiences and mistakes and tried to assure her that there was nothing to fear about delivery. Pregnancy, it was explained to her, "was not an illness." Delivery, on the other hand was like opening the doors for the baby to pass. Mama Fulora pointed out that this rite helped to reduce her fear of child birth. This was her direct source of information on delivery. She was instructed to do all her house chores as well as farm work during pregnancy. Mama Fulora delivered her first child safely at her mother's house. She continued to stay away from her husband, nursing and giving full attention to her baby whom she breast-fed on demand.

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When the baby was about four months old, a special rite was organized for her and her husband. They were now allowed to sleep together but to observe certain restrictions. She wore a contraceptive string called 'pigi' which was supposed to protect her from getting pregnant. She was warned to be careful not to conceive until the child was about two years old, otherwise she would be the laughing stock of the whole village. She was also instructed to take bath immediately after meeting her husband and not to breast feed the baby until she had done so. Carrying a baby immediately after sexual intercourse was said to be dangerous to the baby's health. It was explained that the baby's body cannot absorb so much heat that is subsequently released from the bodies of two adults who had just mated.

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Mama Fulora had nine living children all delivered at home under the supervision of the Traditional Birth Attendants. In the early years, she had helped in delivering several other women and was under the apprenticeship of elderly experienced birth attendants. She later became a professional TBA, a profession with the highest respect in the village.

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Second Case: Salima

Aged 30, with five daughters Salima is already three months pregnant. She aspires to have a baby boy this time. She had her first child when she was sixteen, hardly a year after completing her 16 primary school education. She was thirteen years old in class five of primary school when she had her first menses. Prior to this, her grandmother who had been observing her carefully had told her a short while before the onset of her first menstruation, that she should expect it anytime. As a young girl (between 9–13) before reaching puberty she was referred to as "kigori". She would normally take care of her younger siblings and would do petty errands such as collection of firewood and water. She would also prepare quick meals and do general cleanliness of the house. All in all, she formed part of the daily indispensable female labor force in the home. She was still regarded as a small girl and not expected to have any sexual relations. The family would establish a joking relationship with her while at the same time she would be socially nurtured towards attaining womanhood.

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